PREMACY

How the IAF's leading fighter aircraft stack up against those of China and Pakistan

CHINA

Total number **1,200-1,300**



J-20
No: Over **200**
China's first multirole 5th-generation stealth fighter

J-11 (variants J-11B/BS)
No: Around **350**
4th-generation multirole fighter

J-16
No: Around **350**
Multirole 4.5 -generation multirole fighter like Rafale

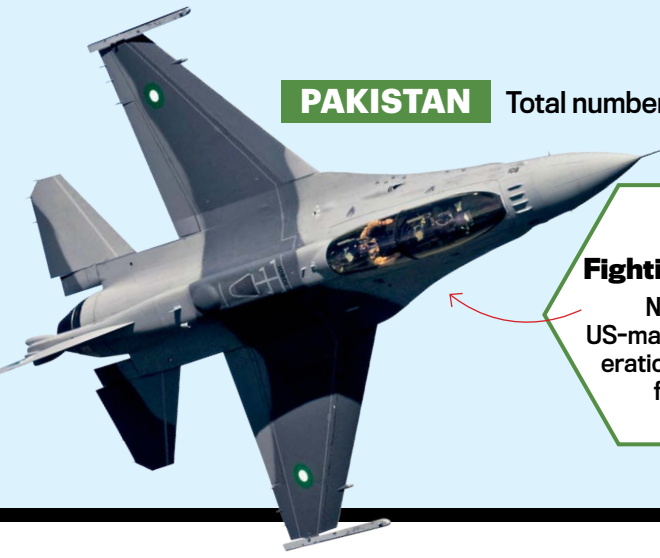
J-10 (variants J-10A/B/C/S)
No: Around **300**
Multirole fighter compared to the upgraded US made F16

J-35 (FC-31)
No: Initial induction
A newer 5th - generation stealth fighter

In development:
Sixth-generation **J36** and **J50**

PAKISTAN

Total number: **445**



JF-17 Thunder
No: **161**
Multirole fighter developed by Pakistan Aeronautical Complex, Chengdu Aerospace Corporation

Acquisition:
Probable purchase 40 **J35** from China

F-16 Fighting Falcon
No: **85**
US-made 4th- generation multirole fighter

Mirage III, Mirage 5
No: **87, 92**
Like Mig-21, Mirage III and Mirage 5 are ageing fighters

J10
No: **20**
Chinese-made multirole fighter

cabinet's go-ahead in March 2024. Besides the wait for funds, the US's indecision on licenced production of jet engines in India threatens to further delay the programme. The ADA has plans to rope in private players for production and maintenance of the forthcoming jets, rather than depending wholly on HAL. The government is expected to make a decision on this soon.

FIXING THE PROBLEM

The air marshal INDIA TODAY spoke to touches upon "the root cause" behind the delayed projects. The R&D, he points out, is a standalone process without any accountability for production, while the production process is also separate, and blames R&D for delays. According to him, in no leading military industrial complex is there such a hard distinction between R&D and production.

"The R&D is authorised only to build prototypes and a budget is accordingly sanctioned. So, R&D focuses on making the prototypes fly without requisite care for series production related aspects," he says. This is the primary reason for LCA Tejas facing serious maintenance issues as HAL had replicated the prototype design for series production, he reveals. When the R&D gets delayed, the production agency is under pressure to churn out aircraft and subsequently passes platforms with missing capabilities, promising to introduce them later. "In this hurry, manufacturing processes for tools and fixtures are hurriedly set up without the acceptable accuracy, leading to mismatch in production standards. Many panels of Tejas are not interchangeable across aircraft," he claims.

Another IAF officer says that part of the R&D needs to be funded by the production agency to ensure they have a say in the design and the prototypes are as close to series production as feasible. "One option is for the government to pair up ADA with a private sector firm with cost sharing in R&D," he says.

Fast-tracking acquisition of fighter jets to fill the gaping hole in numbers and streamlining the development and production of the latest in indigenous design—both are needed to secure India's air defence capabilities in South Asia's increasingly contested skies. ■